

“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life.” (*English Standard Version*, John 3:16).

According to “Five Point Calvinism,” which is accepted in the Presbyterian Church in America (PCA) and the Orthodox Presbyterian Church (OPC), God chooses the people who He will save. These people who God has chosen for salvation are called the “elect.” This notion is unbiblical, yet it is proudly confessed in the Westminster Larger Catechism (Questions 30-32, 34, 45, 64, 66-68, 154), and therefore professed by all confessional Presbyterians.

Total Depravity.

The first point of Calvinistic doctrine is “Total Depravity.” Without God, all men are dead for their transgressions against God’s Law unless man becomes born again.

“For if, because of one man's trespass, death reigned through that one man, much more will those who receive the abundance of grace and the free gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man Jesus Christ.” (*ESV*, Romans 5:17).

It is scriptural that, because of the transgression of Adam, sin entered all mankind. This hereditary sin, original sin, is the consequence of one man falling into temptation. Jesus Christ told Nicodemus that, “unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he can not enter the kingdom of God,” (*ESV*, John 3:5). Through the waters of baptism which save us (*ESV*, Mark 16:16), man is “sprinkled clean from an evil conscience,” (*ESV*, Hebrews 10:22). Man is born again into the Christian Church through baptismal grace, which covers our vile corruption.

“For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.” (*ESV*, Romans 6:23).

Man is dead and totally depraved of life without the grace which all men inherited from Christ’s sacrifice. Man, in this state of death, can not do anything out of supernatural love without God’s call for him to do so. Therefore, Total Depravity is valid.

Unconditional Election.

The second point of Calvinistic doctrine is “Unconditional Election.” God does not determine our salvation, or in Calvinism, “election,” by any standards or conditions other than His own grace.

“...though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad—in order that God's purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls... . For he says to Moses, ‘I will have mercy on whom I

have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion.’ So then it depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy.” (*ESV*, Romans 9:11, 15-16).

It is scriptural that our calling to Christ is not earned through will or deeds. Justification is entirely dependent on the mercy of God. It is through grace that man is justified “so that being justified by his grace we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life.” (*ESV*, Titus 3:7). Grace is certainly not given because of any work that man does out of love, since it is through grace alone that man receives the perfect, supernatural, godly love by which he can truly have perfect faith in God. This faith, as true faith accompanied by love bestowed by grace onto His workmanship (*ESV*, Ephesians 2:8, 10), is the result of this “Unconditional Election.”

“But if it is by grace, it is no longer on the basis of works; otherwise grace would no longer be grace.” (*ESV*, Romans 11:6).

Grace depends on nothing from man because man has nothing to offer on his own. Man, who is totally depraved, can not do anything out of perfect love without God’s call for him to do so.

“And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.” (*ESV*, Romans 8:30).

Man can not choose God on his own. God predestines and calls man to Him. “You did not choose me, but I chose you.” (*ESV*, John 15:16). In His grace, God predestined and called certain “elect” who are unconditionally chosen that they may love Him for eternity.

What does this mean for those whom God does not elect for salvation? According to Calvinism, those who God does not choose undergo “double-predestination.” This means that God foresees those who He elected to spare with His grace and therefore elects others to eternal damnation. A Christian ought to believe that those who do not come to God were not predestined for damnation by their Creator, but rather passively do not come to Him because of their unwashed inherent sinfulness.

If the doctrine of “double-predestination” is true, then Calvinists must answer why a merciful God created some men who He knew He did not plan to save, but who He planned to condemn to eternal suffering?

Limited Atonement.

The third point of Calvinistic doctrine is “Limited Atonement.” This means that, on the cross, Christ was crucified to atone for the sins of the elect, not those “double-predestined” for damnation.

“I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.” (*ESV*, John 10:11).

Calvinists will support this false doctrine with the claim that Christ was the Savior of Christians. In truth, it is scriptural that Christ saved those who believe. It is true then that Christ laid down His life for His sheep [the Christian Church], who Calvinists would say have been elected for salvation. It is unbiblical, however, to say that Christ laid down His life *only* for His sheep. Christ is instead the “Savior of the world.” (*ESV*, John 4:42).

“He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but for the sins of the whole world.” (*ESV*, 1 John 2:2).

Christ’s sacrifice was not only sufficient for His sheep. Christ’s sacrifice was sufficient for the sins of the whole world. Even though His sacrifice was sufficient for all men, it is only effective for those who believe in Him, His sheep. Those who believe have grace which has been won by Christ “the living God, who is the Savior of all people, especially of those who believe.” (*ESV*, 1 Timothy 4:10). Christ is the Savior of all men even if not all men are saved.

“Therefore, as one trespass led to condemnation for all men, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for all men.” (*ESV*, Romans 5:18).

Just because Christ’s sacrifice was only effective for the Church does not mean that the atonement was limited to the Church. By His death, salvation was made open to all men, not just the elect. Death and sin, which entered the entire world through Adam, was conquered by Christ, by whom salvation entered the entire world. The grace of Christ’s death abounds for many (*ESV*, Romans 5:15). God, in His mercy, did not condemn all men for one transgression without a plan of salvation for all men.

“Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her,” (*ESV*, Ephesians 5:25).

Calvinists often quote Paul when he wrote that Christ gave Himself up for the Church. What Paul wrote to the Ephesians is of course true. In Ephesians, however, Paul is only identifying one group who Christ gave Himself up for. God’s love is not limited to the Church, God loves the world (*ESV*, John 3:16). God loves both Jews and Gentiles (*ESV*, Romans 3:29).

If this same logic of “Limited Atonement” was applied to another of Paul’s writings, atonement would be limited even more strictly. In Galatians, Paul wrote, “And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me.” (*ESV*, Galatians 2:20). Calvinists who say that Christ *only* laid down His life for His sheep, the Church, would therefore be forced to admit that Christ *only* laid down His life for Paul.

At different points in Scripture, Paul describes Christ as the Savior of Paul (*ESV*, Galatians 2:20), the Savior of the Church (*ESV*, Ephesians 5:25), and the Savior of the world (*ESV*, 1 Timothy 4:10). All are true because Christ died for all men, not a special group elected by God. Thus, the doctrine of Limited Atonement is false. Even though His sacrifice is sufficient for all men and opens salvation for all men, it is not necessarily obtained by all men.

Irresistible Grace.

The fourth point of Calvinistic doctrine is “Irresistible Grace.” This means that, once an elected man has received God’s saving grace, he is never able to resist it.

“All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out... . No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him. And I will raise him up on the last day. It is written in the Prophets, ‘And they will all be taught by God.’ Everyone who has heard and learned from the Father comes to me.” (*ESV*, John 6:37, 44-45).

It is of course true that man can not find God on his own. Man needs God to call him because he can not himself find true godly faith, hope, or love. In addition, God’s will is perfect. It is impossible for man to try to resist God’s will (*ESV*, Matthew 16:23). Every man, created by God, is called to become a child of God. God’s free and undeserved grace motivates us in this reaction to our calling. Grace is participation in God’s plan. It pushes man towards active participation and life in God. But man, in the free will given by God, has the ability to reject this grace. God Himself will not cast his grace away from any man, but any man may cast himself out from God.

“Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power,” (*ESV*, Psalm 110:3).

God’s people are not forced into submission of grace, but are freely able to offer themselves to God. Actual grace internally and directly enlightens man’s understanding and strengthens his own will. Those who experience vast amounts of God’s grace will certainly accept it, but they will do so freely with the option to deny it. This battle of free will is a battle between God-given understanding and strength against temptation from Satan.

Just because a man denies God’s grace does not mean that he never possessed it. At the fall, Adam certainly fell from his state of sinless grace and godly participation when he was tempted by Satan (*ESV*, Genesis 3:12-13).

““You stiff-necked people, uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit. As your fathers did, so do you... . You who received the law as delivered by angels and did not keep it.”” (*ESV*, Acts 7:51, 53).

In Stephen’s final speech before the Sanhedrin, he chastises the Sanhedrin who were bestowed with the Holy Spirit and the law, meaning grace from the Holy Spirit, but chose to resist it due to the sweet temptations of self-righteousness above the law. Therefore, Irresistible Grace, as applied by Calvinists, is false.

Perseverance of the Saints.

The final point of Calvinistic doctrine is the “Perseverance of the Saints.” This means that, once a man is in a state of God’s saving grace, he can never lose it.

“I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand.” (*ESV*, John 10:28).

“...nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.” (*ESV*, Romans 8:38-39).

Calvinists defend the idea that a man’s salvation is assured for him and refuse to accept mere “hope of eternal life.” (*ESV*, Titus 3:7). To Calvinists, God chose the elect so that they may experience a one-time ‘born again’ experience of salvation and will *know* that they are saved rather than having to *hope* that they are saved. The passages above seem to say that nothing is able to separate God’s people, the elect, from God and salvation. However, these passages are specifically talking about those who are already steadfast in their faith. To a truly faithful believer, no outside source will be able to tempt him from the path to salvation. But some believers, believers who still do have faith, may lose their faith when challenged.

“[God] saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began,” (*ESV*, 2 Timothy 1:9).

Calvinists will often focus on the past tense act of being “saved” (*ESV*, Romans 8:24; Ephesians 2:5, 8; Titus 3:5). However, salvation is really an ongoing process, not a one-time event. Because of Christ’s sacrifice, we have been saved, we are being saved, and we will be saved.

Salvation is a present struggle which man must avoid losing. When he left the church in Philippi, Paul wrote, “work out your own salvation with fear and trembling.” (*ESV*, Philippians 2:12). Man always must be aware of his own state of grace so that he may never fall away from salvation. This is also expressed by Peter who wrote, “Though you do not now see him, you believe in him and rejoice with joy that is inexpressible and filled with glory, obtaining the outcome of your faith, the salvation of your souls.” (*ESV*, 1 Peter 1:8-9).

Salvation is also a future event, where “the one who endures to the end will be saved.” (*ESV*, Matthew 10:22, 24:13). Peter again hoped for future salvation at the Council of Jerusalem when he declared, “we believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus,” (*ESV*, Acts 15:11).

“You are severed from Christ, you who would be justified by the law; you have fallen away from grace.” (*ESV*, Galatians 5:4).

Sometimes Calvinists will use analogies to describe the Preservation of the Saints. One may claim that God’s children will attain eternal security in God’s family. God the Father would

never cast away His own children. However, children in real families do not have this eternal security. Even if their parents do not cast them out, children may cast themselves out. Children can sever ties with their parents. Children can die. So too can man cast himself out from the Father and reject Him, sever ties through “sin, which leads to death” (*ESV*, Romans 6:16), and even spiritually die by losing faith.

“For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found.’ And they began to celebrate.” (*ESV*, Luke 15:24).

Jesus talks about falling from the Father in His parable of the prodigal son. In the verse above, He says that the prodigal son was dead and alive again. The word “again” shows that the son was alive before he died. So too can the faithful fall in and out of true faith, being spiritually alive, dead, and alive again. If the prodigal son had physically died while he was engrossed in sin, he would have died without favor of his father. But because he returned and regained his father’s favor, he was once more saved.

“For when Solomon was old his wives turned away his heart after other gods, and his heart was not wholly true to the Lord his God, as was the heart of David his father.” (*ESV*, 1 Kings 11:4).

King Solomon was once spiritually alive in God. However, in his old age, he turned away from God and became spiritually dead. Calvinists would say that, because Solomon eventually fell away from salvation, he was never part of God’s elect and *never* actually was saved. According to Calvinists, if Solomon had physically died before he spiritually died, he would not be saved because he was never predestined for salvation.

“Not everyone who says to me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter the kingdom of heaven,” (*ESV*, Matthew 7:21).

“Therefore let anyone who thinks that he stands take heed lest he fall.” (*ESV*, 1 Corinthians 10:11-12).

Even if the Perseverance of the Saints was valid, which it isn’t, the subsequent doctrine of the assurance of salvation is not as comforting as Calvinists intended. Although they are relieved of having to “hope” for eternal life, they never know whether they have true faith as one of God’s elect. In fact, no Calvinist can be sure that God loves him, which is much less comforting than hope for eternal life.

Because of the transgression of Adam, sin entered the entire world. But God, who loves the whole world, established a process by which all men may attain salvation. Jesus Christ, the Son of God incarnate, died as a sacrifice so that all men may have hope in eternal life. Even though His sacrifice is not efficacious to all men, it opens the possibility of salvation to all men. Through His grace, this sacrifice was made for all men, not only for those who He “elected.”